

12-Week BCBA Exam Study Schedule

One domain at a time, written to the 6th Edition Test Content Outline

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The BCBA exam is built from the BACB BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.): 9 domains, 104 tasks, 175 scored questions plus 10 unscored pilot questions, four hours (BACB, 2022). This schedule assigns each domain to a week and spaces practice across all of them, a study strategy shown to improve long-term retention (Roediger & Butler, 2011).

Twelve weeks is enough for a candidate who has finished coursework and can study about ten hours a week. If you have less time, compress the foundation weeks; do not compress the mock-exam weeks. Each week, split study time three ways: new content for the week's domain, practice questions with the rationale read for every item, and a short definitions review.

Weeks 1-2: Foundations

- Domain A: Behaviorism and Philosophical Foundations (5 tasks, 8 scored questions)
- Domain B: Concepts and Principles (24 tasks, 24 scored questions): B.1 to B.12 in week 1, B.13 to B.24 in week 2
- Daily: build and review a definitions deck as you go (SAFMEDS or flashcards)

Weeks 3-4: Measurement and Baseline

- Domain C: Measurement, Data Display, and Interpretation (12 tasks, 21 scored questions)
- Practice: reading graphs and choosing a measurement system for a described behavior
- Week 4: take a timed practice set that reports results by domain and record your accuracy for each domain. This is your baseline.

Weeks 5-6: Design and Ethics

- Domain D: Experimental Design (9 tasks, 13 scored questions): single-case designs, internal validity, and when each design fits
- Domain E: Ethical and Professional Issues (12 tasks, 22 scored questions): read the Ethics Code for Behavior Analysts alongside the E tasks, not instead of them

Weeks 7-8: Assessment and Behavior-Change Procedures

- Domain F: Behavior Assessment (8 tasks, 23 scored questions): preference, descriptive, and functional assessment; interpreting the data
- Domain G: Behavior-Change Procedures (19 tasks, 25 scored questions): reinforcement, prompting, shaping, chaining, generalization, punishment
- Apply each procedure to a written case scenario before you move on

Weeks 9-11: Integration and Full Mock Exams

- Week 9: Domain H: Selecting and Implementing Interventions (8 tasks, 20 scored questions) and Domain I: Personnel Supervision and Management (7 tasks, 19 scored questions). Goal writing, intervention selection, procedural integrity, supervision.
- Weeks 10 and 11: one full-length timed mock exam each week (185 questions, four hours). Spend the rest of the week reviewing every missed item against its task number.

Week 12: Review and Rest

- Light review of your lowest two domains from the mocks. No new material.
- Reread your own notes on the questions you missed twice.
- Take the day before the exam off.

What to track

Keep one page per domain. Each time you miss a question, write the task number, what the question was really testing, and the rule you should have applied. By week 9 those pages are your personalized review guide. Four signals tell you whether you are ready: domain accuracy (consistently correct in every domain), response time (about 75 seconds per question without rushing), consistency (the same result on a domain across several sessions), and mock endurance (holding accuracy through the fourth hour).

References

Behavior Analyst Certification Board. (2020). Ethics code for behavior analysts.

Behavior Analyst Certification Board. (2022). BCBA test content outline (6th ed.).

Roediger, H. L., & Butler, A. C. (2011). The critical role of retrieval practice in long-term retention. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 15(1), 20-27.

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